BONUS SCENE

KING OF ENVY

#1 NEW YORK TIMES BESTSELLING AUTHOR

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AYANA

No.

"Come on," I cajoled. "It'll look so good on you!"

No.

"Vuk." I crossed my arms. "You promised you would go into this vacation with an open mind."

My mind is open. My wallet isn't—not for that monstrosity.

I tamped down a bubble of laughter and tried to maintain a stern expression. "I'll buy it for you as a gift. It would look so great on you when you're, um, walking to the beach."

Vuk's scowl deepened. We were standing in our hotel's signature boutique, which sold everything from fifty-dollar seashell-shaped soaps to luxury resort wear—including the bright tropical-print men's shirt I was holding.

I'd suggested he try it on as a joke, but the more I thought about it, the more I was determined to break him out of his comfort zone. The man was wearing all black on a Caribbean island, for Pete's sake. And as hot as he looked—both literally and figuratively—he couldn't stomp around Anguilla in boots for the next four days, no matter how much he wanted to.

“Ayana, I love you,” Vuk said after the boutique’s sales associate moved out of earshot to assist another customer. “But I would rather order one of those tropical drinks you like so much and stick the plastic umbrella through my eye than wear anything so…” He paused, clearly searching for the right word to express his disdain. “Loud.”

We both stared at the shirt. Okay, so the orange, white, and green pattern wasn’t exactly subtle, but we were on vacation! If there was a time to be loud and carefree, it was now.

I lowered my voice. “If you wear this shirt, I’ll make it worth your while tonight.”

“You can’t bribe me with sex.”

“You sure?”

“Yes.”

I shrugged, feigning nonchalance. “Then I guess you won’t get to see the new lingerie set I bought for this trip. It’s too bad. It makes the teddy I wore during our Finland trip look like a potato sack.”

A beat passed.

Vuk’s jaw ticked.

The sales associate finished with her customer and beelined back toward us, but before she could offer to help again, Vuk snatched the shirt from my hand and stomped toward the register.

I suppressed a grin and followed him.

Just to be clear, I’m not buying this because of your lingerie, he signed while the associate rang us up. ***I’m buying it so we can stop arguing.***

“Fine,” I said. “But the lingerie promise didn’t hurt, did it?”

Vuk’s lips pressed into a thin line, but the glitter in his eyes told me he wasn’t as annoyed as he pretended to be.

I’d planned on putting on a show for him tonight regardless of whether he bought the shirt or not. We had four glorious days alone together, and I

was going to take advantage of every second—but he didn't need to know that.

Vuk paid for the shirt, and I looped my arm through his elbow before we made our way back to our villa. We were staying at a luxury resort in Anguilla, and it was so quiet I could hear the ocean in the distance.

This. This was exactly what we needed.

Life had been a nonstop whirlwind since we returned from our Finland trip over the holidays. I was fully booked with modeling gigs and the new mentorship program I was spearheading to help young models navigate the industry. Meanwhile, Vuk was busy with his company's latest product launch and upcoming board meeting. On top of all that, we had a wedding to plan.

It was scheduled for this fall, and my mom was over the moon about the fact that she could *finally* have the reception of her dreams after my engagement to Jordan fell apart. Vuk and I had ceded most of the planning to her, but there was still plenty for us to do—seating charts, outfit customizations, pre-wedding festivities—which was why we'd planned this getaway to recharge before we jumped back into the fray.

It was funny. Despite the never-ending list of to-do's, I wouldn't give up the experience for anything in the world. I'd dreaded planning my wedding to Jordan, but I savored every moment of the process with Vuk.

It turned out being in love with your fiancé made a huge difference in personal enjoyment. Who would've thought?

We entered our villa, which overlooked the water and was decorated in a stunning palette of blues and greens. Sunshine bathed the rooms in a warm golden light, and it smelled like a mix of fresh flowers and salt-tinged sea air.

I loved the excitement of the city, but sometimes, nothing hit like a remote island escape.

I flopped onto the king-size bed as Vuk pulled his shirt over his head.

“Now that you have the appropriate clothing, how do you feel about some beach time?” I asked casually. “It’s too late for sunbathing, but we can have the concierge arrange some activities for us. Snorkeling, diving, sailing, water skiing…”

Personally, I didn’t think it was too late to sunbathe, but it was our first day here. I didn’t want to scare Vuk off with too much, too soon. Given his aversion to sand and surf, the fact that he’d agreed to come here in the first place was nothing short of a miracle.

His expression suggested he hated all of the options, but when he opened his mouth, he simply said, “Which one do you want to do?”

I mulled it over. As fun as snorkeling and diving were, I wasn’t in the mood for something that adventurous right now. Water skiing seemed nice in theory, but I’d watched too many wipeout videos online to risk looking like an idiot on what was supposed to be a relaxing vacation.

“Let’s do the sunset sail,” I decided. “A private boat ride with champagne sounds like the perfect first evening in Anguilla.”

“You’re going to make me wear that hideous shirt on the boat, won’t you?”

“Oh, absolutely.”

I didn’t get the chance to say another word before he grabbed my ankles and pulled me toward the edge of the bed. I squealed with laughter as he climbed on top of me, his face set in a playful scowl.

“You’re going to pay for that.” He mock glared at me.

“Really?” I raised an eyebrow, my cool tone belying the sudden spike in my pulse. Vuk was still shirtless, and his body heat enveloped me like the world’s most delicious blanket. Whoever said the spark in a relationship died after one year didn’t know what they were talking about. If anything, ours was stronger now than when we first started dating. “How so?”

A devilish gleam entered his eyes. “Oh, I can think of a few ways.” He skimmed his lips up my neck, his kisses agonizingly light compared to the

sudden need coiling in my stomach. My breaths shallowed, and I had to fight the urge to roll him over and have my way with him right then and there.

Vuk's uncanny ability to get me in the mood with a single touch should be studied.

"We're supposed to go sailing." I sounded unconvincing to my own ears.

"Not until sunset." Vuk reached my mouth and nipped my lower lip with his teeth—not hard enough to break skin, but firm enough to send a zing of heat through my blood. "We have a good two hours left before we need to head out."

A dim part of me recognized that we hadn't called the concierge yet to set up our sailing excursion, nor had we unpacked or eaten dinner. I'd been so excited about the resort that I'd dragged him outside immediately after checking in.

However, all that seemed trivial compared to the—

"*Oh*." I let out a soft gasp when Vuk's hand reached between my thighs. *God*, the man was a genius with his fingers. And his mouth. And his, well, everything. "Wait. Don't you want to see that lingerie set first?"

"I want to see it eventually." He slipped his fingers beneath my underwear. "But do you really want me to stop now?"

Good point.

We didn't speak much after that, nor did we make it dinner *or* our sunset sail. But later that night, as I lay sated and curled up beside him, I didn't even care that we'd spent the majority of our first day in our hotel room. As long as I was with Vuk, I was happy.

"I suggest we spend the rest of our vacation like this," he said. He stroked my bare shoulder, his voice husky the way it always was after sex. "Inside, naked, out of the sun…"

I laughed. A caveat to what I said earlier about being happy as long as I was with him—that was true, *but* I wasn't going to let him waste a perfectly good island getaway either.

"Let's compromise." I propped myself up on my elbow so I could look at him more easily. "I get the hours between breakfast and dinner; you get the hours between dinner and sunrise. We'll do whatever the other person wants within those time frames."

Vuk gave me a droll look. "How stupid do you think I am? That'll give you control over basically the entire day."

"Not stupid," I corrected him. "*Accommodating*. In fact, if you think about it, the hours between dinner and sunrise are the best hours, so I'm really the one making a sacrifice here."

Laughter rumbled from his chest. "Be glad I love you so much."

I took that as a yes.

"I am." I kissed him again, unable to stop a grin from spreading across my face. We were being the cheesiest, sappiest couple ever, but who gave a fuck? We were alone, and we were happy. That was all that mattered. "I love you too, and I promise I'll show off my lingerie tomorrow. Really. Until then, I think there's still quite a few hours left before sunrise…"

Like I said, those were the best hours. And I enjoyed every single second of them with Vuk.

She's his greatest rival…and his greatest weakness.

Continue the Kings of Sin series with King of Gluttony, Sebastian & Maya's story.

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